

Teaching Statement

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1 Background

My first experience with teaching began in high school. I had good grades, and people assumed that good grades meant good tutoring skills. While I don't think that connection is generally true, it introduced me to one of the activities I enjoy most: teaching and tutoring. I remember an instance when I helped a friend of my brother to prepare for a comprehensive eighth-grade math exam. In a month, he went from knowing very little about the material to mastering it. He is now a college graduate.

After college, my first job was as a lecturer at the University of Costa Rica, teaching Introduction to Economics for three semesters. That experience remains one of the happiest periods of my life, with lively class discussions, meaningful student engagement, and supportive colleagues—important inputs in my decision to pursue a PhD. At UCSD, I have served as an instructional assistant for more than 15 quarters, mostly in microeconomics or behavioral/experimental economics, but also in econometrics and a conservation economics course. I have also been the primary instructor for two summer courses: Econ100B, a core upper-division course, and Econ171, an elective on decisions under uncertainty. Econ100B was intense, with a large amount of material condensed into four weeks. Econ171 allowed me to teach the foundations of my own research.

Why I teach. Teaching is the bridge between discovery and understanding. It brings knowledge to life, sparks questions that feed back into research and applications, and allows me to share topics I am passionate about—including my own research—while challenging students intellectually. Teaching also shapes worldviews, opens doors to possibilities students may not have imagined, and serves society by contributing to an educated citizenry and the formation of future leaders, professionals, and policymakers.

Role of Research. Research is an important input into teaching. Staying active in research keeps instructors current, exposes them to emerging debates and challenging ideas,

and enriches their teaching. Sharing my own research and that of leading scholars can likewise expose students to cutting-edge ideas and inspire curiosity and deeper engagement with the discipline.

Looking ahead, I am particularly excited about teaching microeconomics (theory and applied), behavioral and experimental, business, and mathematics for economists; but I'm open to teach any economics or business course.

2 What I consider the four big pillars of teaching

1. Effective knowledge transmission. The core of teaching is helping students understand and retain knowledge. I integrate active learning into every class, including in-class practice problems, peer discussions, collective problem-solving, and mini case studies where students take the perspective of policymakers or business managers. These activities reinforce concepts from the lecture and keep students engaged, allowing them to process material before moving to the next topic.

Unlike other highly technical fields like geology or quantum physics, economics provides plenty of direct opportunities to connect formal models to decisions and institutions students encounter in everyday life. A successful lecture should direct students to visualize concepts and ideas as naturally as they would a story, making abstract models feel like natural, coherent narratives. I start with the basic intuition behind a concept before introducing technical details, using stories and examples to bridge the gap between theory and application. By translating economic jargon and formal notation into relatable narratives, students can internalize both the “why” and the “how” of economic ideas.

In Econ100B, 94.7% ($N = 19$) of the students who answered the teaching evaluation, agreed or strongly agreed with the question that class sessions helped them understand the course content. Likewise, across the 2024-26 courses I served as teaching assistant, the average score for the learning/engagement rubric is 94% ($N = 173$) agree/strongly agree.

2. Focus on practical relevance. Most students are not aiming for a PhD and may not be primarily interested in research. They are most engaged when they can relate the material to their own lives or imagine applying it in the near or distant future. I think of this as the “practical value” of what they are learning.

Generating a sense of practical relevance is easier in some classes than others. In a course on portfolio management, the applications are obvious; in a class on measure theory, it requires more effort. I believe it is a crucial part of lecture design to connect abstract

concepts to examples students can relate to.

For instance, in Econ171, after covering the theory of demand and supply of insurance, I illustrated the concepts using real insurance contracts, including student health insurance.

In the Econ100B teaching evaluation, I added two customized items regarding this element, as I had it present since I was designing the course. For the “The instructor effectively related the course material to real-world applications or situations outside of the classroom.”, 95% of the students agree/strongly agree. For “The instructor maintained a balance between theoretical concepts and practical applications throughout the course.”, 90% of them agree/strongly agree.

3. Empathy. Being a student is often difficult. You are constantly tested, exposed to challenging material, and at the same time, navigating the pressures of life outside the classroom. Learning becomes far more meaningful when the instructor recognizes these struggles and responds with empathy. This does not mean lowering standards or compromising rigor. Rather, it means demanding excellence while also being mindful of students’ challenges and remembering that a single kind word can make a profound difference.

I received this impactful comment in the last reflection assignment for Econ100B:

“I think the most important thing I’ve learned is confidence. When you mentioned in the last lecture that someone had said they hated econ during the first class, that was me. I’ve been lurking here because I always got very poor grades in previous economics classes. This left me feeling very confused and lacking confidence. But you provided me with confidence. Your thorough explanations made it very easy for me to understand the content you taught. This made me think, perhaps the previous professors didn’t teach as well as you do? But it doesn’t matter anymore. I believe that’s the case. Thank you for making me realize that I am not a poor student!”

I don’t think this was a reflection of an “easy” class, but the voice of a student who felt heard, supported. This highlights the profound emotional impact an instructor can have on a student’s confidence and life.

In the Econ100B teaching evaluation I received 100% agree/strongly agree responses for the welcoming and supportive learning environment item. Likewise, across the 2024-26 teaching assistant evals, I received an average 95% in the supportive environment item.

4. Joy. Teaching is performative. Like a musician or an actor, a teacher develops a presence in the classroom. Each lecture is an opportunity to keep students engaged, entertained, and intellectually stimulated. I call this value **joy** because, much like performers who seem to be having the time of their lives on stage, teachers should radiate enthusiasm

for their subject. While delivery is not everything, the classes I enjoyed most as a college student were those where the professor taught as if it were the most exciting job in the world, and this ranged from proof-based calculus to the history of economic thought. That sense of joy is contagious.

There are not specific “joy” items in the teaching/teaching assistant evaluations, but as several comments show consistently across classes, students emphasize a positive and entertaining attitude in my lectures. I include two examples: *“He has a very funny and relatable lecturing style that makes me comfortable to answer the question or say that I don’t know the answer.”* (Econ142, 2025) *“He was a very positive person with positive attitude which encouraged and engaged me to attend and listen in class.”* (Econ100B, 2024 as Instructor)

3 Assessments

Exams are an important evaluation tool, but should not dominate course grades. I avoid relying exclusively on high-stakes exams because a single assessment captures only a limited dimension of student learning. Exams measure a specific type of performance; grades should reflect broader engagement with material.

I design exams using Bloom’s taxonomy, incorporating conceptual multiple-choice and fill-in-the-blank questions, short-answer questions requiring qualitative reasoning, and quantitative problem-solving. This approach balances cognitive levels and helps me gauge whether students grasp underlying ideas, not just problem-solving techniques.

Students benefit from alternative ways to demonstrate learning, such as presentations, projects, and reflections. Low-stakes formative assessments—quizzes, homework, etc.—prepare students for summative evaluations while reducing anxiety.

I particularly like reflections because they encourage students to interact in ways they normally would not in a lecture or an exam. In Econ100B, I asked students to “find a topic you like and think how class material could help answer a question.” One student identified the lack of competitive teams in the Mexican women’s soccer league as a topic that could be studied through producer theory and cost analysis. This is a specific example of a student effectively connecting abstract class concepts to real-life matters.

4 Perceived Challenges: Teaching in 2026

In my last two teaching classes, I followed a policy of not incentivizing course evaluations. I believe providing feedback on the education they receive is part of students' responsibility, both to their instructors and to future students who may take the course, and therefore that students should complete course evaluations without the need for academic incentives. This was not a problem in Econ100B in Summer 2024 (66% response rate of 29 students enrolled). However, in Econ171, only 2 out of 13 students completed the evaluation, so the university system did not generate a report. I found this disappointing, and it prompted me to reflect on some of the broader challenges I perceive in teaching today.

I worry that students may not see college today with the same sense of purpose and enthusiasm as in the past. According to a 2025 Gallup report, the share of 18- to 34-year-olds who consider a college education “very important” fell from 74% in 2013 to 35% in 2025¹. AI adds another layer to this challenge, raising questions about the value of a college degree and which skills students should develop as technology advances at unprecedented rates.

I see this as a challenge to reinforce the value of the four pillars described above. Teaching students is not enough; we also need to help them appreciate the process of learning and recognize how what they learn can apply beyond a particular course or exam, now more than ever. Our biggest challenge is how to use these tools to support higher education rather than replace it. This makes the human dimension of teaching even more important. Empathy, meaningful interaction, and the joy of learning are experiences that cannot be reduced to obtaining an answer from a tool.

My goal is therefore not simply for students to leave my courses knowing more economics, but to leave with a greater appreciation for learning, greater confidence in their ability to reason, and a sense of how economic ideas can be useful beyond the classroom.

¹<https://news.gallup.com/poll/695003/perceived-importance-college-hits-new-low.aspx>